

LEAVE POLICY

Comprehensive HR Policy Document

Human Resources Department
Version 1.0 | Effective from January 1, 2025
Classification: Internal Use Only

POLICY OVERVIEW
This Leave Policy establishes the comprehensive framework for all types of leave entitlements available to employees of the organization. It covers Casual Leave, Sick Leave, Paid Leave (Earned Leave), Maternity and Paternity Leave, Public Holidays, and all other special leave categories. The policy ensures fair, consistent, and compassionate treatment of all employees during personal, medical, and family-related absences.

1. PURPOSE, SCOPE, AND PHILOSOPHY

1.1 Purpose

This Leave Policy exists to:

- Define clearly the types of leave available to employees and the conditions for each.
- Ensure employees understand their entitlements and how to apply for them.
- Provide managers with clear guidelines for approving, rejecting, or modifying leave requests.
- Protect the organization's operational needs while respecting employees' personal and medical needs.
- Ensure compliance with applicable labor laws and statutory requirements.
- Foster a culture of trust, transparency, and mutual respect between employees and management.

1.2 Scope and Applicability

This policy applies to all employees of the organization regardless of:

- Gender, age, religion, marital status, or place of origin
- Designation, seniority, or pay grade
- Type of employment (full-time, part-time, probationary, or contractual — with appropriate limitations)

Specific leave categories may have differentiated entitlements by employee type, as outlined in the respective sections. Contractual employees should refer to their individual contracts for any variances.

1.3 Leave Philosophy

The organization believes that well-rested, healthy employees are more engaged and productive. Leaves are therefore not a privilege but a right, and employees are encouraged to utilize their leave balances appropriately. The organization discourages 'leave shaming' — the practice of implying that taking leave reflects poor work ethic. Managers who discourage employees from taking entitled leave will be subject to disciplinary review.

1.4 Leave Year / Policy Year

The Leave Policy Year runs from January 1 to December 31 each calendar year. Leave balances are credited at the beginning of each policy year. For employees who join mid-year, leave entitlements are pro-rated based on the date of joining.

Joining Month	Pro-Rated Leave (Approx.)
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January – March	Full-year entitlement
April – June	75% of annual entitlement
July – September	50% of annual entitlement
October – December	25% of annual entitlement

2. LEAVE SUMMARY CHART

The following table provides a consolidated overview of all leave types, entitlements, and key conditions:

Leave Type	Annual Entitlement	Carry Forward	Encashment
Casual Leave (CL)	12 days	No (lapses year-end)	No
Sick Leave (SL)	12 days	Up to 15 days max	No
Earned / Paid Leave (EL/PL)	18 days	Up to 30 days max	Yes (on exit)
Maternity Leave	26 weeks (female)	N/A	No
Paternity Leave	15 days (male)	N/A	No
Adoption Leave	12 weeks (primary caregiver)	N/A	No
Bereavement Leave	5 days per occasion	No	No
Compensatory Off (Comp-Off)	As accrued	60 days max	No
Leave Without Pay (LWP)	As approved	N/A	N/A
Study / Examination Leave	Up to 10 days/year	No	No

3. CASUAL LEAVE (CL)

3.1 Definition and Purpose

Casual Leave is intended for unforeseen personal needs, minor illnesses, urgent personal matters, or short-duration events that require an employee to be away from work for a brief period. It is the most flexible form of leave and does not require advance documentation.

3.2 Entitlement

- All confirmed employees: 12 days per calendar year
- Probationary employees: 6 days per calendar year (pro-rated by joining month)
- Part-time employees: Pro-rated based on weekly working hours

3.3 Key Rules and Conditions

- Casual Leave cannot be taken for more than 3 consecutive days. For longer absences, the employee must apply for Sick Leave, Earned Leave, or other appropriate leave category.
- Casual Leave cannot be prefixed or suffixed to a public holiday or weekly off to extend a break without prior manager approval.
- Casual Leave cannot be combined with Earned Leave or Sick Leave in a single application.
- Unused Casual Leave at the end of the policy year lapses and cannot be carried forward, encashed, or converted to any other leave type.
- A maximum of 1 day of Casual Leave may be taken as a half-day per occasion.

Parameter	Details
Annual Quota	12 days
Max Consecutive Days	3 days
Advance Notice Required	Preferred; not mandatory for genuine emergencies
Documentation Required	No (for up to 3 days)
Carry Forward	Not permitted
Encashment	Not permitted
Half-Day Option	Yes — available
Applies to Probationers	Yes (6 days, pro-rated)

3.4 Procedure to Apply for Casual Leave

1. Log in to the HRMS portal (<https://hrms.yourcompany.com>).

2. Navigate to 'Leave Management' > 'Apply for Leave'.
3. Select 'Casual Leave' from the leave type dropdown.
4. Enter the dates, select full-day or half-day, and provide a brief reason.
5. Click 'Submit' to forward the request to your reporting manager.
6. The manager has 24 hours to approve or reject.
7. You will receive an email and in-app notification upon decision.

Real-World Example: Casual Leave

Pooja's child falls sick on a Monday morning. She calls her manager at 8:45 AM to inform her, then applies for Casual Leave on the HRMS portal. Since this is her first CL application of the month and she has a balance of 8 days remaining, it is approved within an hour. Pooja's balance updates to 7 days. She does not need to provide any medical certificate for this absence.

Real-World Example: CL Misuse Avoidance

Rohit wants to extend his weekend by taking Monday off after a national holiday on Saturday. He applies for Casual Leave on Monday. His manager reviews the application and notices it immediately follows a holiday. While this is permissible, the manager checks if it exceeds any CL suffix/prefix limits. Since Rohit has given reasonable notice and has sufficient balance, it is approved. However, if this becomes a pattern every holiday, the manager may raise a concern.

3.5 Emergency Casual Leave

If an employee is unable to apply in advance due to an emergency:

- They must notify their manager by phone or message before 9:30 AM on the day of absence.
- They must submit the HRMS leave application on the same day or the next working day.
- Failure to notify within 24 hours of the first day of absence will result in the day being marked Unauthorized Absent.

4. SICK LEAVE (SL)

4.1 Definition and Purpose

Sick Leave is granted to employees who are unable to attend work due to personal illness, injury, hospitalization, or medical procedures. Sick Leave is distinct from Casual Leave and requires medical documentation for extended absences.

4.2 Entitlement

- All confirmed employees: 12 days per calendar year
- Probationary employees: 6 days per calendar year
- Part-time employees: Pro-rated based on days worked per week

4.3 Key Rules and Conditions

- For absences of 1–2 days: A self-declaration in the HRMS is sufficient.
- For absences of 3 or more consecutive days: A medical certificate from a registered medical practitioner (MBBS or higher) must be submitted within 3 working days of return.
- For hospitalization: Discharge summary and doctor's certificate must be submitted within 7 days of return.
- Sick Leave may be prefixed or suffixed to public holidays and weekends.
- Sick Leave availed without valid illness documentation (discovered through investigation) will be converted to Leave Without Pay.

Absence Duration	Documentation Required
1–2 days	Self-declaration on HRMS portal
3–7 consecutive days	Medical certificate from registered physician
8+ days (extended illness)	Doctor's certificate + fitness-to-resume letter
Hospitalization	Discharge summary + treating doctor's certificate
Surgery / Procedure	Surgery report + leave recommendation by doctor
Chronic Illness	Specialist report; HR may arrange occupational health review

4.4 Sick Leave Carry Forward

Unlike Casual Leave, unused Sick Leave can be carried forward to the next policy year with the following rules:

- Maximum carry-forward balance: 15 days at any time
- Sick Leave carried forward does not expire as long as employment continues

- Sick Leave cannot be encashed at any time, including upon resignation or retirement
- Example: If an employee has 12 days SL balance and uses only 4, they carry forward 8 days to next year. In the next year, they receive another 12 days for a total of 20 days, but the maximum balance cap of 15 days means they start with 15 days, not 20.

NOTE: Sick Leave encashment is not permitted at any point — not on separation, retirement, or resignation. Unused SL simply ceases at the end of employment.

4.5 Sick Leave During Probation

Employees on probation are granted 6 days of Sick Leave. Excessive sick leave during the probation period may be considered a factor in the probation completion review, particularly if patterns suggest misuse. However, genuine illness supported by medical documentation will not prejudice probation outcomes.

Real-World Example: Sick Leave with Documentation

Vikram is diagnosed with typhoid and is bed-ridden for 9 days. His wife calls HR on Day 1 and applies for Sick Leave on his behalf through the HRMS (she has been designated as his emergency contact). On Day 7, Vikram's doctor provides a certificate. Upon return, Vikram submits the original medical certificate and a fitness-to-resume letter. HR records all 9 days as Sick Leave. His remaining SL balance is 3 days, and 0 days are carried forward from the previous year.

4.6 Repeated Short-Term Sick Leave (Pattern Analysis)

HR may initiate a medical review if an employee demonstrates a pattern of short-term sick leave, such as:

- Sick leave consistently on Mondays or Fridays (extending weekends)
- Sick leave immediately before or after holidays
- More than 8 instances of 1-day sick leave in a rolling 6-month period

In such cases, HR may request a Fitness Certificate or arrange an occupational health consultation — not as punitive measures, but to ensure the employee's health is properly supported.

5. EARNED LEAVE / PAID LEAVE (EL / PL)

5.1 Definition and Purpose

Earned Leave (also called Paid Leave or Annual Leave) is leave that employees accrue based on time worked. It is the most valuable leave type as it can be carried forward and encashed. EL is intended for planned rest, holidays, travel, personal projects, or family time — to ensure employees maintain long-term wellbeing.

5.2 Entitlement and Accrual

- Annual entitlement: 18 days per year for confirmed employees
- Accrual rate: 1.5 days per month of service
- Accrual begins: From the date of confirmation (not probation start)
- Leave is credited on the 1st of each month for the previous month's service

Accrual Detail	Value
Annual Entitlement	18 days
Monthly Accrual	1.5 days per month
Accrual Starts From	Date of employment confirmation
Minimum Leave Application	1 day (half-day EL not available)
Advance Notice Required	Minimum 7 days (except emergencies)
Maximum Consecutive Days	30 days (beyond needs Department Head approval)
Carry Forward Cap	30 days maximum balance at any time
Encashment at Separation	100% of balance up to the carry-forward cap

5.3 Key Rules and Conditions

- EL must be applied for with a minimum of 7 days advance notice, except in emergencies.
- EL application is subject to manager and/or HR approval. Business requirements may result in deferral.
- EL can be combined with public holidays to create longer vacation periods, subject to approval.
- EL can be availed in a single stretch or split into multiple applications.
- If EL balance is exhausted and additional time is needed, Leave Without Pay (LWP) applies.
- EL balance is frozen (not accrued) during unpaid leaves exceeding 30 days.

5.4 Earned Leave Carry Forward

Earned Leave that is not used within the policy year is automatically carried forward, subject to the following:

- Maximum EL balance at any time: 30 days
- Once the balance reaches 30 days, no further accrual occurs until the balance is reduced
- Employees are encouraged to plan and take their EL regularly to avoid losing accrual capacity

Real-World Example: EL Carry Forward Cap

Ashwini joined in January 2022 and has never taken Earned Leave. By December 2024, her EL balance has reached 30 days (the maximum cap). Starting January 2025, her HRMS stops accruing new EL until she takes some leave and reduces her balance. Her HR Business Partner sends her a reminder email encouraging her to plan a vacation. She applies for 10 days of EL in March 2025, after which her balance drops to 20 days and accrual resumes.

5.5 Earned Leave Encashment

Earned Leave can be partially encashed in specific circumstances:

- Upon resignation: Full EL balance (up to 30 days) is encashed at the time of Full and Final Settlement.
- Upon retirement: Full EL balance encashed per service entitlement rules.
- Annual Optional Encashment: Employees may encash up to 10 days of EL per year in lieu of availing it, subject to HR approval and budget availability. Encashment rate = $(\text{Monthly Basic Salary} / 26) \times \text{Number of Days}$.

Real-World Example: EL Encashment on Resignation

Karan resigns with 25 days of EL balance. His monthly basic salary is Rs. 40,000. EL encashment = $(40,000 / 26) \times 25 = \text{Rs. } 38,461.54$. This amount is included in his Full and Final Settlement statement. He is also eligible for EL encashment for any approved notice period adjustments.

5.6 Mandatory Leave Requirement

Employees in sensitive roles (finance, treasury, IT security, audit) are required to take a minimum of 7 consecutive days of Earned Leave in a calendar year as part of risk management and fraud prevention protocols. This mandatory leave window is coordinated between the employee, manager, and HR at least 30 days in advance.

6. MATERNITY LEAVE

6.1 Legal Basis

Maternity Leave is a statutory entitlement governed by the Maternity Benefit Act, 1961 (as amended). All female employees who have worked for the organization for at least 80 days in the preceding 12 months are entitled to maternity leave.

6.2 Entitlement

Condition	Maternity Leave Entitlement
First and second child (biological)	26 weeks (182 days)
Third child and beyond	12 weeks (84 days)
Adoption of child under 3 months	12 weeks from date of adoption
Commissioning mother (surrogacy)	12 weeks from date the child is handed over
Miscarriage / Medical Termination	6 weeks following the date of miscarriage/MTP
Tubectomy (sterilization)	2 weeks following the procedure
Illness arising from pregnancy	1 month additional on top of eligible maternity leave

6.3 Pre-Natal and Post-Natal Split

Of the 26 weeks of maternity leave:

- Up to 8 weeks (56 days) may be taken before the expected date of delivery.
- The remaining weeks (minimum 18 weeks) are available post-delivery.
- Employees may choose a different split subject to medical advice and HR approval.

6.4 Pay During Maternity Leave

Maternity Leave is fully paid:

- Full basic salary + allowances continue during the entire maternity leave period.
- Salary is paid directly to the employee's bank account as per the normal payroll cycle.
- No deduction from any other leave balance occurs during maternity leave.
- Employees continue to accrue Earned Leave during maternity leave.

NOTE: Reducing pay, changing job role, demoting, or threatening dismissal of a female employee due to pregnancy or maternity leave is unlawful and constitutes a grave violation of the

Maternity Benefit Act and organizational policy. Such actions will result in immediate disciplinary action against the perpetrator.

6.5 Work-from-Home Post Maternity Leave

As per the Maternity Benefit (Amendment) Act, 2017, the organization facilitates a work-from-home arrangement for new mothers after the conclusion of maternity leave, where the nature of the job permits. The terms of such an arrangement are mutually agreed between the employee, manager, and HR.

6.6 Crèche Facility

The organization provides crèche facility support for female employees with children under 6 years of age, in compliance with the Maternity Benefit Act. Employees may visit the crèche up to 4 times per day during working hours without deduction of break time.

6.7 Procedure for Maternity Leave Application

8. The employee must notify HR and the reporting manager at least 4 weeks before the planned leave commencement date.
9. Submit the Maternity Leave Application Form on the HRMS along with the doctor's estimated delivery date certificate.
10. HR will issue a formal Maternity Leave Sanction Letter within 5 working days.
11. Any extension (due to medical complications or premature delivery) must be communicated immediately with medical documentation.
12. A return-to-work plan will be discussed with the employee at least 2 weeks before the leave end date.

Real-World Example: Maternity Leave

Ananya is 7 months pregnant and plans to go on maternity leave 4 weeks before her due date. She submits the HRMS application and doctor's certificate. HR approves 26 weeks (8 pre-natal + 18 post-natal). She delivers on schedule. After 6 weeks post-delivery, she requests WFH for 8 weeks as a transitional measure, which her manager approves for Tuesdays and Thursdays. She returns full-time after 26 weeks. Her salary during the entire period is unaffected.

7. PATERNITY LEAVE

7.1 Definition and Purpose

Paternity Leave allows male employees to be present during the birth of their child, support their partner during recovery, and bond with the newborn. The organization recognizes the importance of shared parental responsibility and encourages fathers to avail this leave without hesitation.

7.2 Entitlement

Condition	Paternity Leave Entitlement
Birth of first or second child (biological)	15 days
Third child and beyond	7 days
Adoption (where mother is not an employee here)	7 days
Stillbirth or neonatal death	5 days of paid bereavement-paternity leave

7.3 Key Rules and Conditions

- Paternity Leave must be taken within 90 days of the child's birth or date of adoption.
- Paternity Leave is fully paid.
- It can be taken in one continuous block or split into two parts (e.g., around delivery and during the first month).
- Paternity Leave cannot be accumulated, carried forward, or encashed.
- Employees must provide a birth certificate or hospital discharge summary within 30 days of availing the leave.

7.4 Applying for Paternity Leave

13. Submit the Paternity Leave Application via HRMS with the expected date of delivery.
14. Provide prior intimation of at least 7 days, unless the delivery is premature or emergency.
15. Post-delivery, submit a copy of the birth certificate or hospital document within 30 days.

Real-World Example: Paternity Leave

Sunil's wife delivers their first child on a Thursday. Sunil had already applied for Paternity Leave starting that Friday. He takes 15 days in total — 5 days from Friday through the next week and the remaining 10 days split across the following month as needed. His salary is unaffected. He submits the birth certificate to HR within 2 weeks. His manager arranges workload coverage during his absence.

7.5 Organizational Stance on Paternity Leave

The organization takes an active stance in encouraging paternity leave. Managers may not pressure employees to cut short or forgo paternity leave due to workload. Any such pressure should be reported to HR, which will intervene to protect the employee's statutory and organizational rights.

8. ADOPTION AND COMMISSIONING LEAVE

8.1 Adoption Leave for Female Employees

Female employees who legally adopt a child below the age of 3 months are entitled to 12 weeks of paid adoption leave. This is governed under the Maternity Benefit Act amendment and carries the same protections as biological maternity leave.

8.2 Adoption Leave for Male Employees

Male employees who adopt a child below the age of 3 months are entitled to 7 days of paid adoption leave (treated as Paternity Leave).

8.3 Commissioning Mother (Surrogacy)

A 'commissioning mother' — a woman who commissions surrogacy — is entitled to 12 weeks of paid leave from the date the child is handed over to her. Proof of surrogacy and the commissioning agreement must be submitted to HR.

Real-World Example: Adoption Leave

Kavitha and her husband adopt a 1-month-old girl. As a female employee, Kavitha is entitled to 12 weeks of paid Adoption Leave starting from the date the child is officially handed over. She applies with her adoption order and handover certificate. HR approves the leave immediately. Her husband (working elsewhere) must seek adoption leave from his own employer.

9. BEREAVEMENT LEAVE

9.1 Definition and Purpose

Bereavement Leave is granted to employees who lose an immediate family member. The organization recognizes grief as a deeply human experience and ensures employees have adequate time to cope, attend to funeral rites, and stabilize emotionally before returning to work.

9.2 Entitlement and Eligible Relationships

Deceased Relation	Bereavement Leave Entitlement
Spouse	5 working days
Child (biological or adopted)	5 working days
Parent (biological or adoptive)	5 working days
Sibling (biological or step)	3 working days
Parent-in-law	3 working days
Grandparent	2 working days
Close relative (uncle, aunt, cousin)	1 working day

9.3 Key Rules and Conditions

- Bereavement Leave must be applied within 3 working days of the bereavement event.
- A death certificate or cremation/burial certificate is required for leave beyond 1 day.
- Bereavement Leave is fully paid and does not deduct from any other leave balance.
- Bereavement Leave may be combined with Casual Leave or Earned Leave if more time is needed.
- HR will handle such requests with sensitivity and may waive documentation in exceptional circumstances.

Real-World Example: Bereavement Leave

Deepak's father passes away suddenly on a Wednesday. He informs his manager immediately via phone. HR is notified the same day. HR approves 5 days of Bereavement Leave without requiring any documentation at the outset. Upon return, Deepak submits the death certificate. His manager also arranges a team meeting to welcome him back warmly. HR schedules a brief check-in call to ask if Deepak requires any counseling support through the EAP.

10. PUBLIC HOLIDAYS

10.1 Overview

The organization observes a set of National and State Public Holidays each year. The official Holiday Calendar is published by HR by November 30 of the preceding year and is accessible on the HRMS portal. Employees are entitled to all gazetted holidays as per the calendar.

10.2 National Holidays (Mandatory — No Work)

National Holiday	Date (Fixed)
Republic Day	January 26
Independence Day	August 15
Gandhi Jayanti	October 2

10.3 Restricted / Optional Holidays

In addition to National Holidays, the organization observes a set of Optional (Restricted) Holidays. Employees may choose any 2 optional holidays from the official Optional Holiday List published each year. Examples include:

- Eid-ul-Fitr
- Christmas Day
- Diwali (additional day)
- Ugadi / Gudi Padwa / Bihu / Onam / Pongal (regional)
- Guru Nanak Jayanti
- Mahavir Jayanti
- Good Friday
- Buddha Purnima

Employees must apply for Optional Holidays through the HRMS at least 3 days before the holiday date. Unused optional holiday credits lapse at year-end.

Holiday Type	Entitlement / Process
National Holidays	3 days — Mandatory; no application needed
State Holidays	As per state; automatic in HRMS for the region
Optional Restricted Holidays	Choose any 2 from approved list; apply via HRMS
Floating Holidays	Up to 1 per year; as directed by management for local occasions

10.4 Holiday Falling on a Weekly Off

If a Public Holiday falls on a Sunday (weekly off), a substitution holiday (a 'holiday in lieu') is granted on the immediately preceding or following working day. HR communicates this in the annual holiday calendar. If a holiday falls on a Saturday, no substitute is provided (as Saturday is a regular working day).

10.5 Working on a Public Holiday

If business requirements necessitate working on a Public Holiday:

- The decision must be communicated by the Department Head to HR and employees at least 48 hours in advance.
- Employees who work on a mandatory national holiday receive 2x overtime pay OR a compensatory off day.
- Employees who work on optional/restricted holidays receive 1.5x overtime pay OR a compensatory off day.
- Female employees may decline to work on public holidays without citing any reason. Their attendance on such days is purely voluntary and cannot be mandated.

Real-World Example: Working on Independence Day

The IT operations team is required to be on standby on Independence Day for a critical system migration. Employees who attend are given the choice of 2x overtime pay or a comp-off day to be taken within 60 days. Three team members opt for overtime pay; two opt for comp-off. All five are required to submit their preferences to HR via HRMS by the preceding Thursday.

11. COMPENSATORY OFF (COMP-OFF) LEAVE

11.1 Definition

Compensatory Off (Comp-Off) is granted to employees who are required to work on weekly offs, public holidays, or beyond standard working hours (for non-overtime-eligible staff). It is a form of rest that compensates for lost personal time.

11.2 Accrual Rules

- Working 8+ hours on a Sunday or public holiday: 1 full comp-off day
- Working 4–7 hours on a Sunday or public holiday: Half comp-off day
- Overtime work for non-eligible grades: As per Overtime Policy (see Attendance Policy)

11.3 Conditions for Utilization

- Comp-off must be pre-approved by the manager before being applied.
- Comp-off must be utilized within 60 calendar days of accrual. After 60 days, it lapses permanently.
- Comp-off cannot be encashed under any circumstances, including at separation.
- Comp-off balance is visible on the HRMS under the 'Comp-Off' leave type.

Real-World Example: Comp-Off Lapsing

Shalini worked on a Sunday in February and accrued 1 comp-off day. By April (60 days later), she had not used it. The HRMS automatically removes the comp-off from her balance on the 61st day. An automated reminder email was sent to her and her manager on Day 45 and Day 55 urging her to plan the comp-off. This is considered a lapsed benefit and cannot be retrieved retroactively.

12. LEAVE WITHOUT PAY (LWP)

12.1 Definition

Leave Without Pay (LWP) is an approved absence during which the employee does not receive salary for the days absent. It is granted when all other paid leave balances have been exhausted or when the employee requests an extended break not covered by any other leave type.

12.2 When LWP Applies

- The employee has exhausted all applicable leave balances (CL, SL, EL) and still requires time off.
- The employee voluntarily applies for extended personal leave beyond standard entitlements.
- Unauthorized absences are retrospectively converted to LWP (after deducting any leave balance first).
- Leave applied during notice period that exceeds earned leave balance.

12.3 Approval Process

16. The employee submits an LWP request on HRMS with detailed justification.
17. The reporting manager reviews and recommends approval or denial.
18. For LWP exceeding 10 days, HR Head approval is required.
19. Approved LWP is deducted directly from the month's salary: $(\text{Gross Monthly Salary} / \text{Total Working Days}) \times \text{LWP Days}$.

12.4 Impact of LWP

- Salary deduction for each LWP day.
- EL accrual paused during extended LWP (beyond 30 continuous days).
- Continuity of service is maintained for LWP up to 30 days; beyond that, service continuity may be affected for PF and gratuity calculations.

NOTE: Repeated LWP applications may be flagged during performance appraisal discussions. Employees are encouraged to plan leaves responsibly and utilize their entitled leave types before resorting to LWP.

13. STUDY, EXAMINATION, AND SPECIAL LEAVES

13.1 Study / Examination Leave

The organization encourages continuous learning and professional development. Employees pursuing relevant academic courses or professional certifications (e.g., CA, MBA, CFA, CISA, PMP) may apply for Study Leave:

- Up to 10 working days per calendar year for examination-related activities.
- Must be supported by the exam hall ticket / enrollment proof.
- Leave is paid and does not deduct from CL, SL, or EL.
- The course or certification must be relevant to the employee's current or future role.
- Manager approval is required before application is forwarded to HR.

13.2 Sabbatical Leave

Senior employees (5+ years of service) may apply for Sabbatical Leave for the purpose of research, advanced study, social work, or personal development:

- Duration: 1 to 3 months
- Nature: Unpaid (LWP applies) unless a specific sabbatical scholarship arrangement is made
- Role held open for return, unless business conditions change significantly
- Requires Department Head + HR Head approval, at least 60 days in advance

13.3 Disaster / Community Service Leave

In case of declared national disasters, the organization may grant 1–3 days of paid leave to employees who volunteer in disaster relief or community service activities, with appropriate proof of engagement (e.g., NGO certificate, relief organization letter).

14. LEAVE MANAGEMENT BEST PRACTICES

14.1 Leave Planning

Employees and managers are expected to plan leaves in advance to minimize disruption:

- EL applications should ideally be submitted 7–14 days in advance.
- During peak business periods (year-end, quarterly closings), leave may be deferred.
- Managers must ensure adequate team coverage before approving leaves.
- HR will publish 'Leave Blackout Periods' (if any) at the beginning of each year. Leave applications during blackout periods require special approval.

14.2 Leave Rejection and Deferral

A manager may reject or defer a leave request if:

- Business requirements cannot accommodate the employee's absence at the requested time.
- The employee has insufficient leave balance.
- The absence would leave a critical function unattended without a valid backup.

In such cases, the manager must communicate the rejection/deferral reason within 48 hours of the application and suggest alternative dates. Leave cannot be rejected without a valid reason or without an offer of alternative dates.

Real-World Example: Leave Deferral

Finance Manager Shilpa applies for 10 days of EL starting March 25 — which coincides with the organization's year-end closing period. Her Department Head defers her leave to April 15 instead, explaining the business criticality. Shilpa agrees, and the EL is rescheduled on HRMS. When April arrives, her revised leave dates are approved without issue.

14.3 Recall from Leave

In rare emergency situations, the organization may need to recall an employee from leave. If this occurs:

- The manager must seek HR approval before recalling the employee.
- The employee is given at least 24 hours' notice (except in declared emergencies).
- Any non-refundable travel or accommodation costs incurred by the employee due to the recall will be reimbursed with proof.
- The number of remaining leave days will be restored to the employee's balance.

15. COMPLIANCE, CONFIDENTIALITY, AND AMENDMENTS

15.1 Legal Compliance

This Leave Policy is designed in accordance with the following laws and regulations:

- The Maternity Benefit Act, 1961 (and amendments up to 2017)
- The Factories Act, 1948
- The Shops and Establishments Act (applicable state)
- The Payment of Wages Act, 1936
- The Minimum Wages Act, 1948
- The Code on Social Security, 2020 (where notified and applicable)
- The Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace Act, 2013 (leave related provisions)

15.2 Confidentiality of Leave Records

All leave records are confidential personal employment data. Access is restricted to:

- The employee themselves
- Their reporting manager
- HR Department
- Legal / Compliance team (on need-to-know basis)

Sharing or discussing another employee's leave records without authorization is a disciplinary violation.

15.3 Misuse of Leave

Leave misuse includes but is not limited to:

- Applying for Sick Leave when not unwell and without medical documentation when required
- Extending leave beyond the approved period without informing HR or the manager
- Submitting forged or fraudulent medical certificates
- Applying for leave under the wrong category to gain additional benefit

Any confirmed misuse of leave will result in immediate salary deduction, disciplinary action, and a formal note in the employee's personal file. Repeated misuse or fraudulent documentation is grounds for termination.

Real-World Example: Leave Misuse Detected

An employee applies for Sick Leave for 4 consecutive days but is seen posting vacation photos on social media during those days. A colleague informs HR. HR conducts a discreet review. Since the employee did not provide a medical certificate (required for 3+ days SL), HR requests one upon return. The employee is unable to produce it. HR deducts the 4 days as LWP and issues a formal written warning. The employee's leave application privileges are flagged for the next 6 months.

15.4 Policy Amendments

This Leave Policy may be amended by HR at any time. Significant changes will be:

- Communicated to all employees via email and HRMS notification at least 15 days before effective date
- Accompanied by a summary of key changes
- Acknowledged by all employees electronically through HRMS

CONTACT HR FOR ASSISTANCE
HR Department Email: hr@yourcompany.com
HR Helpline: +91-XXXX-XXXXXX Available: 9:00 AM – 5:30 PM (Mon–Sat)
HRMS Portal: https://hrms.yourcompany.com HR Office: Ground Floor, Admin Block
For any leave-related queries, balance discrepancies, application issues, or
special leave circumstances, please contact your HR Business Partner or raise
a ticket on the HRMS portal. All queries will be responded to within 24 hours.

— END OF LEAVE POLICY DOCUMENT —

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